

MY LIFE

An impossible bouquet

Raghava KK

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DEDICATION

For my four little monkeys

I

SAVIOUR TWIN

We are each other's ultimate sidekicks, ready to tackle any adventure with a dose of laughter and a touch of mischief.

For all practical purposes, Kaesava was like an extension of myself. We dressed in identical clothes, despite looking completely different. We slept together, woke up together, brushed our teeth together, and even had our nanny bathe us together. We were inseparable. I wouldn't be surprised if we even kept each other company while sitting on the potty.

We entertained each other so well that we never felt the need for a third person to be around. We lived inside our very own superhero comic book, complete with episodes, allies, villains, and crises. We even had our own arch nemesis - Stella!

Stella, our stay-at-home nanny, was a tall, lean, mean woman with a dark complexion. She always had turmeric smeared on her face and spoke broken English and Tamil. Life seemed to frustrate her in general.

Stella had a very short temper, and I had become quite skilled at predicting her outbursts over time. Her face would contort into an angry expression, resembling Jim Carrey's in "The Mask." Her fists clenched tightly, and her tongue would fold back between her gritted teeth. Stella only unleashed this fury when our parents weren't around. We knew that if we ever revealed this side of her to our parents, we would be in grave danger. So we kept quiet, until the day came when we had no choice but to speak up. That was the day Stella packed her bags and left us forever. We stood by our mother's side, not moving an inch, until Stella physically left the premises.

One day, when I returned home from playing outside, I witnessed Stella yelling at my brother, pinning him against the bathroom wall, ready to unleash her wrath upon him. In a moment of heroism, I leapt onto Stella's back, grabbing onto her oily, braided hair and gold chain, and yanked with all my might. She choked and released my brother. Stella lost her balance on the wet floor and fell to the ground, with me landing on top of her. Her sari became undone, but I didn't care. I was prepared to do whatever it took to protect my twin brother. Strangely, instead of retaliating, Stella calmed down and withdrew. We never spoke of that incident again. It was our secret, our first victory against Stella.

As children, Kaesava and I were left to our own devices most of the time. We passed the time by playing make-believe games, creating scenarios and acting them out. Since we were making up the story as we went along, we had to narrate what would happen while simultaneously acting it out. The scenarios changed in real time

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"Uh-oh, we're stranded in the middle of the sea. Okay?" I would say.

"Don't worry, brother. I'll find a way to get us back home. Okay?" Kaesava would respond.

Every time the scenario changed, we would seek each other's consent with a simple "okay?"

Kaesava would nod in agreement with all my suggestions. Sometimes, he would even add a bit of pride for himself.

"Thank God I have you, brother. I have a magic wand that can show us the way home. Okay?" Kaesava would declare.

Reluctantly, I would nod, incorporating his contribution to our imaginary adventure.

"Yes, but you need to remember the magic words," I would reply.

"I'll sing you a lullaby and put you to bed. While you're asleep, you'll suddenly remember them. Okay?"

And so, the play-acting continued until Kaesava grew tired, and I grew bored. Then it was time to run out and play with our neighbors.

We lived in a spacious bungalow located on Laurel Lane, a small lane with only five houses, in the heart of Bangalore. My grandmother had purchased this house using the money she had secretly stashed away over the years. The house was big enough to have hidden passages, rooms, dark alleyways, and secret terraces that only skilled climbers could access. In Kaesava and my room, there were numerous storage cupboards positioned above the air conditioner, which were ideal for hiding from unwanted tutors. The air conditioner provided us with the perfect leverage to springboard ourselves into the storage units when ever we needed to go incognito.

Kaesava and I always believed that our house was designed perfectly to play hide and seek and our room perfect to play dark room.

At seven in the morning, we were forcibly jolted from our beds by a frustrated and impatient Stella. As usual, I had left an oval-shaped, dirty, ochre-colored pool of warm fresh urine that my twin brother was used to waking up in.

The sheets were pulled off the bed with urgency and flair, before we even had a chance to find stable footing on the floor. We rubbed our eyes as our pants were yanked off in one swift motion. However, our jubbas always got stuck, scratching our sleepy faces and jolting us awake. We were led into our large bathroom, where Stella had prepared hot water for a scorching wake-up bath. Sometimes, we cried during our baths, but Stella's hard skillful hands swiftly wiped away our tears and muffled our sounds.

We were perfectly fine immediately after our combing routine was finished knowing that the toucher was behind us for the day. Stella would douse us in pond's talcum powder and then have us wear our clothes. She would tuck our shirts into our tiny trousers, put on our socks and shoes and rotate us by the ends of our shirts to make sure we were ready to be presented to our parents who were waiting to have breakfast with us.

Fresh air greeted us at the dining table as Appa sat with his newspaper. Amma was still asleep. Stella, with a wide smile on her face, fed us our dosas, making sure nothing fell on our clean clothes. We said goodbye to our dad as we were instructed, and then Stella took us to school. Our driver Sunder had already started up our white Ambassador car, which was waiting in the parking spot of our house, ready for its first drive of the day.

On certain random lucky days, our driveway would be blocked by a deep ultramarine ambassador car, waiting to take us to school. In the back seat, our petite grandmother sat, barely visible except for her bony hands adorned with dangling gold bangles, enthusiastically waving hello as if trying to make up for not being able to see us. Sometimes, it held out two éclair candies. We would rush to the car, grab them, and then get in from the other side to kiss Jayamma's cold, saggy, Nivea cream-laced cheeks. She'd return our kisses with a pop sound that burst into our tiny ears. We would tell her all about our adventures with our neighbours. The ride to school was only ten minutes, but it was worth it when she came.

On the days that she didn't surprise us, Kaesava and I had a routine planned for our ride to school. Every day, I had to tell him the same stories about how the nuns of the convent we passed by harbored some untellable secrets, possibly related to prisoners. I also told him about the large dome-like structure by St. Joseph College, which we believed to be a king's crown that had been transformed into an observatory to communicate with him after he died and became a star. We didn't worry too much about the size of the crown building, as it appeared small from our vantage point. Three stories later, we reached the school gates. Stella, sitting in the front like the proud orchestrator of the twins, grinned until the door opened and we were dropped off. We didn't bother to wave goodbye because we had to start our second round of rituals once we got to school.

The second round of rituals involved us running to our classrooms. The objective was to distract each other so that we could be the first to say specific words while passing certain landmarks.

We had to say "scrape" while pressing our hands along the rugged cement wall at the entrance to the cycle stand. Then, we had to say "demand" while passing the toilet, and finally "cut" on the last step of the stairway before entering our respective classrooms.

According to the rules of St. Joseph Boys High School, twins were not allowed to be in the same class. As a result, we were often placed in neighboring classrooms.

Now, we would only see each other during the snack and lunch breaks. The time between those breaks was just a blur for me. I would be busy thinking about the adventures we could go on during our snack break.

I can barely recall anything about what went on in the classrooms during this period. I came to life outside the classroom and went into hibernation within its walls.

Before the school bell could set us free, I was already packed up and often the first to leave my classroom. On occasional days when I had a pee accident, I would hold myself from running and wait for enough people to gather before venturing out with my bag held in front of my pants. I felt free as soon as I reached my car, which was always waiting for us in the same location. Stella was always there, usually more relaxed at this time of day. She had her break from us. We would go home, change immediately, pretend to do homework for about an hour, and then we were free until dinner time.

It seemed as though all the families on our lane, except Dr. Waheed's, who had no kids our age running around the streets, came to some understanding together. They decided to implement a curfew that would apply to all the kids.

We didn't have any adults watching over us. We were self-organized and self-mediated. Let me introduce you to the kids in my neighborhood.

To the left side of our house, there was Imran, who was surprisingly simple-minded, and his younger brother Faizan, who was too young to be noticed by us. Across the street from us, there was the Khudhrat Ali family, who had too many kids and an exhausting number of grandkids. Among them, Tita (whose real name was Najaf), Faisal, Maharooq, and Farheen were close to my age. To our right, there lived a bachelor who was a bit strange. He had a girlfriend and two dogs, Speedy and Gonzales, but no kids. Naseer, the grandson of his cook, was my best friend in the whole wide world. Tita, Faisal, Naseer, and Imran were four to six years younger than Kaesava and me, while Fahreen and Maharooq were a year younger but in the same grade as us. By default, that made Kaesava and me the oldest of the group, and I styled myself as their leader.

As the self-styled leader, I took it upon myself to organize several initiatives. One of these was the Laurel Times newspaper. This initiative owes credit to the newly opened xerox shop on the main road parallel to our lane. During a cycling adventure on the main Richmond road with Naseer, we noticed a new signboard for a small and dingy xerox shop. We followed the claustrophobic staircase into the building's basement and found an even smaller room where a man stood with his xerox machine. We asked him about the cost of a copy, and he said it was 50 paisa, which was my daily allowance.

Usually, Naseer and I would spend our evenings by renting two bicycles from Johnson Market for 25 paisa and buying 5 murukoos for another 25 paisa. However, on this day, we

decided to give up our evening jaunt and instead create something worth photocopying.

Naseer and I rushed back home to my mother's closet, which was off-limits to us. We borrowed her fancy new Brother typewriter and took it to our room. After several wasted attempts, we had a newspaper with fresh news and gossip about our little Laurel Lane. We called it The Laurel Times. It was only one page long and had reserved space for potential advertisements. Since this was our first issue, we created a fake ad in the hopes of inspiring potential advertisers. The ad read, "This is your last chance to come and see our stone collection at 5 Laurel Lane. We have some very rare stones." It also mentioned an entry fee of 25 paisa.

Before distributing the newspaper, Kaesava, Naseer, and I decided to reorganize the downstairs guest room in our house to resemble an exhibition venue for our non-existent stone exhibition. We needed to be prepared for an influx of visitors. About ninety percent of the collection, consisting of approximately forty exhibition pieces, was hastily assembled random rubbish. Any stone that looked interesting was included in the collection. However, there were a few truly rare stones that I decided to include, such as three pieces of the Berlin Wall that had recently come down. My mother was in Berlin and brought back a few pieces for us. We also went gold scouting in Kolar Golf Fields and collected any stone that showed traces of ochre, assuming it was gold. Overall, we did have a group of visitors that we had to gather during playtime to come and visit the exhibit, but none of them were willing to pay the entry fee. Out of frustration and generosity, we opened it for free to any willing visitor. At least the exhibition received coverage in the Laurel Times.

Other headlines and news read, "Najaf is mad at his brother for hitting him with a hockey stick. If he does not apologize, he will not be allowed to play with the rest of us."

It also mentioned some provocative headlines that, in hindsight, I regret including for Naseer. Naseer, who could hardly read, was taken advantage of. I asked him to describe what he found attractive about the new girl in our lane, Fahreen. He told me that he liked everything about her but couldn't provide specific details. After some prodding and prompting, he mentioned that her walk, smile, cheeks, and accent made him excited. The gossip section of the Laurel Lane Times quoted Naseer expressing these exact traits as his love for Farheen. All I can say is that the first edition was such a huge success that it not only led to several subsequent editions of The Laurel Lane Times but also inspired my class to start its own newspaper, complete with crossword puzzles and more. It turned out that the father of a boy in my class was a paper manufacturer and was happy to print editions for free. We had a thriving newspaper business, and I served as its editor.